AVAnnotate Open Source Application for Audiovisual Digital Exhibits and Editions (Workshop)

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This half-day workshop is for researchers and libraries, archives, and museums (LAM) professionals who seek to increase access and discovery with audiovisual archives. Beyond the cost of digitization and technical issues with media playback systems, lack of discoverability or awareness of audiovisual materials is the highest challenge cited by researchers and LAM professionals who seek to make AV artifacts accessible to and usable in research and teaching ("AV Primary Sources: Survey of Academic Libraries 2024"). Librarians, archivists, scholars, and publics often create discoverability for AV artifacts through the difficult and time-consuming work of creating contextual information in metadata and descriptions. In light of these needs, this workshop introduces AVAnnotate (https://av-annotate.org /), an open-source application and a workflow for building digital exhibits and editions with annotated audiovisual artifacts. Designed by Dr. Tanya Clement, Brumfield Labs, and Performant Solutions, AVAnnotate is built using minimal computing principles (Clement et. al 2022): it is free-to-use and leverages open-source resources such as GitHub and IIIF (International Interoperable Image Framework), making it well-suited for archivists and librarians promoting standardized modes of accessibility and discovery with AV archival collections.

AVAnnotate depends on user annotations. Annotating has been a methodology in the humanities for adding contextual information to texts since the Middle Ages, but it is also an important aspect of digital information technologies, providing structures and frameworks that influence how digital texts appear and how readers, viewers, and listeners access them (Clement and Fischer 2021). In digital editions and exhibits, annotating is a scholarly methodology that facilitates other humanities methods such as discovering, comparing, referring, sampling, illustrating, and representing (Unsworth 2000). With audiovisual materials, annotations provide essential metadata that makes AV indexable. Because IIIF is a standardized solution that libraries and archives have adopted to give users the ability to perform scholarly methods for research and teaching using third-party platforms like AVAnnotate, IIIF creates new opportunities for exchanging, collaborating, and sharing scholarly annotations for AV. The kind of "round-trip" sharing of resources—from LAMs to the community and back into the LAM system—that AVAnnotate has the potential to create inspires a technical and social ecosystem of knowledge production that will increase the responsible use and sustainability of cultural heritage AV with community-shared knowledge (Clement et. al 2022). Scholars, students, and the public have created projects to provide context for under-used and culturally sensitive historical audio and film recordings.

Workshop leaders will teach by introducing IIIF for AV and showcasing example AVAnnotate projects such as a bilingual edition of recordings from Radio Venceremos – a popular, clandestine radio station from the Salvadoran Civil War (1981-1992) period – and an exhibit from the Gloria Anzaldúa collection at the LLILAS Benson Latin American Studies and Collections at the University of Texas at Austin; a classroom project from the Stella Adler film collection at UT's Harry Ransom Center; newly discovered recordings from a 1953 Harvard Summer School Conference including Ralph Ellison amongst other literary luminaries; oral histories from the Fortunoff Holocaust Testimonies at Yale University; and peer-reviewed, scholarly publications for AV scholarship created by AVAnnotate partners. These projects are significant case studies that demonstrate AVAnnotate approaches to developing interventions into practices around creating AV access and spark conversation about the changing nature of open and participatory humanities scholarship.

First, participants will learn how to use the AVAnnotate application, which starts with creating or using existing IIIF manifests, developing annotations, and building static web pages with GitHub Pages to present and share digital exhibits. Workshop leaders will teach through showcasing example AVAnnotate exhibits by showing the process used to create projects using select recordings and IIIF manifests from the Internet Archive. Finally, participants will be invited to discuss protocols for accessing audiovisual artifacts at their respective institutions, and how applications such

as AVAnnotate can facilitate engagement with AV collections.

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